attention on and off like a tap. That's why, when it comes to myself, I wouldn't ever complain about the media putting me in the spotlight. There have been times in my life when it's helped me, no question, especially when I was starting out as a young pro at United. And, in recent years, definitely once France 98 was behind me, I think I've had a pretty good deal from the press: they've been positive and generous towards me more often than not. The soccer writers really helped me settle into the job of England captain.

Mostly, though, it's men who run the papers and perhaps that explains some of the snide stuff that gets written and said about Victoria. It gets under our skin. But then my wife's a grown up and can look after herself. The one area where I really do think the media should have a long look at what they do is getting in the faces of children who happen to have famous mums and dads. Brooklyn and Romeo haven't asked for Posh and Becks as parents. It makes me angry—more than that, it makes me sad—that I can't take the boys to a park or to the beach without the cameras coming out. It spoils it for me but that's not the point. I remember Southend with Mum and Dad, evenings after school in Chase Lane Park. Even though my sons aren't aware of it—not yet, anyway—they're being cheated out of some of the best bits of their childhoods because the press can't leave them alone.

I appreciate the role the media's had to play in bringing me the rewards I enjoy. Right now, I'm really pleased that most people seem to like me and respect what I do, as a soccer player, a husband and a father. In the back of my mind though, because of what happened after the World Cup in 1998, I'm aware that everything could change. It might be something of my own doing; it might be nothing to do with me, just people's moods changing. When you're talking about fame and what comes your way with that, you know you can't be in control all the time. If the tide turns, I can't expect to be able to stop that. All I can do is be ready for it—if it ever happens—and be comfortable enough with myself to deal with it in my life. That's another reason why it's so important to me that I look after what I feel surest about: my family. I want my wife and my children to be there for me. I want Victoria and Brooklyn and Romeo to know that I'm going to be there for them. If I have the love of my family wrapped up inside me, I'm absolutely sure that I'll be able to face whatever comes.

I grew up in the love of a family. Without Mum and Dad, none of my story would be here for the telling. Like any son, I wouldn't have grown up into the person I am if they hadn't passed on their values to me.

Marriage and parenthood, I think, are the two most important things any